Planning an Event?

Learn how chaos can drive engagement

Learn how controlled chaos can drive deep attendee interaction and transform event engagement.

whoami

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- **Senior Community Manager (AWS)**

  OpenSearch Project & Software Foundation – Marketing Committee & Technical Steering Committee.
- **Fosstodon**

  Fediverse admin for the Fosstodon instance and serves as a Fosstodon Foundation Board Member
- **Traveler and gardener**

  When I’m not traveling to conferences, I enjoy gardening at home with my family



krisfreedain

Goals for this talk

- **Conferences & Community:** What is this idea, how is it different from other types
- **How, what, why:** Let attendees propose subjects they care about, driving immediate buy-in and engagement
- **Expectations:** Subjects can vary greatly, and that's a good thing
- **Notes for organizers:** Lessons learned after conducting these for a few years

Conferences & Community

Carefully planned and scheduled

The Organizer's Dilemma

Traditional Rigidity

Fixed schedules and one-way lectures encourage passive consumption. Attendees sit quietly, leaving genuine networking relegated to brief coffee breaks.

Controlled Chaos

Letting the room propose, vote, and decide on a schedule transforms passive spectators into active co-creators, fostering organic peer-to-peer knowledge sharing and high energy.

Other ways to ‘unconference’

Scripted unconferences, Barcamp, BOAF

All are great options – but let's propose something different



By Samwalton9 - Own work, CC BY-SA 4.0, https://commons.wikimedia.org/w/index.php?curid=83180210

Introduce a little chaos

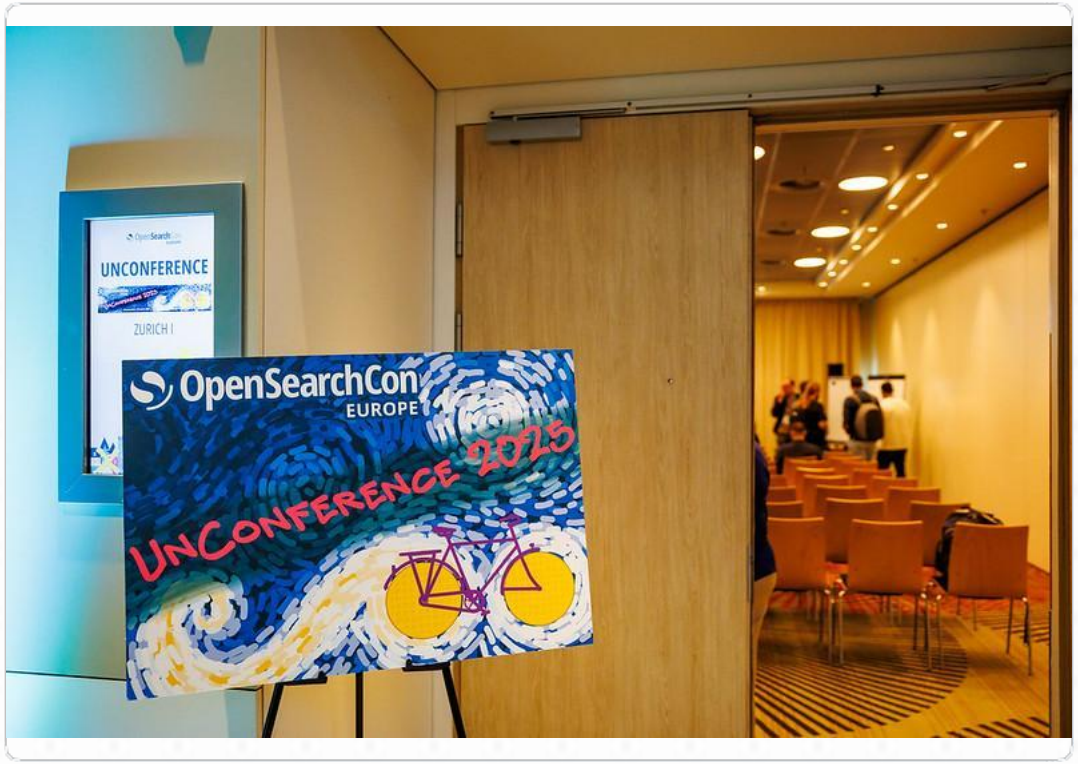
Unconference

Time for some real fun with your community



What is an Unconference?

- **Participant-Driven:** Talks are proposed in the first ten minutes, then voted on for the next ten.
- **Engagement-Driven:** Engagement starts when attendees walk in the door. Chaos is a key to success.
- **Lowered Barriers:** Slide decks are optional. The floor is yours for the set amount of time.



How, What, Why

Let attendees propose subjects they care about, driving immediate buy-in and passion

Among friends

100%

Proposed, scored, and presented in-room

Empowering your community

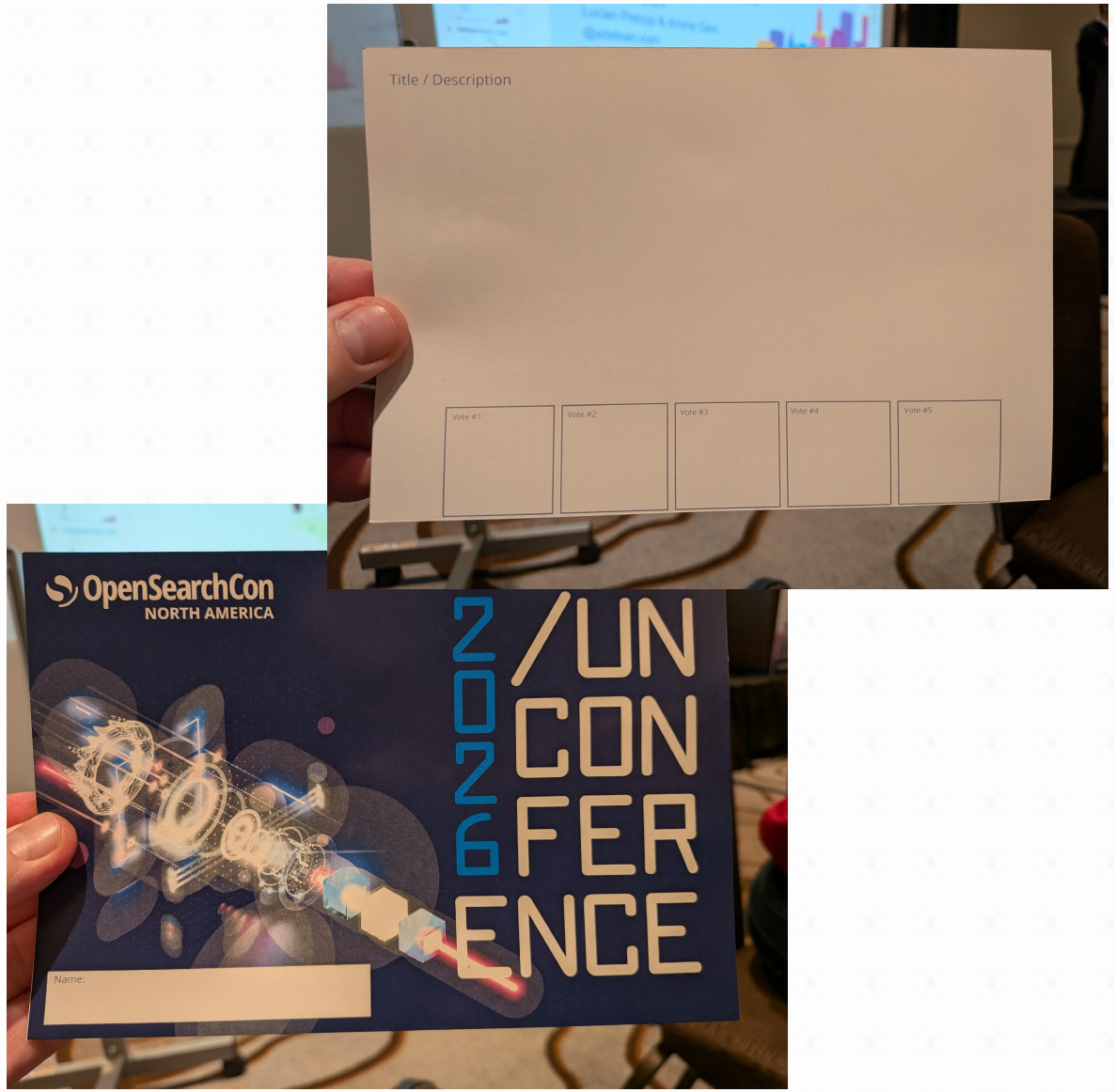
Imagine walking into a room with other learners in your community. You are welcomed to bring your ideas and essentially run through the submission process, panelists, and session announcements all within a 20-minute period.

It is, but it's also a lot of fun.

Proposals

Simple cards

Give them a way to write their proposal



Proposals







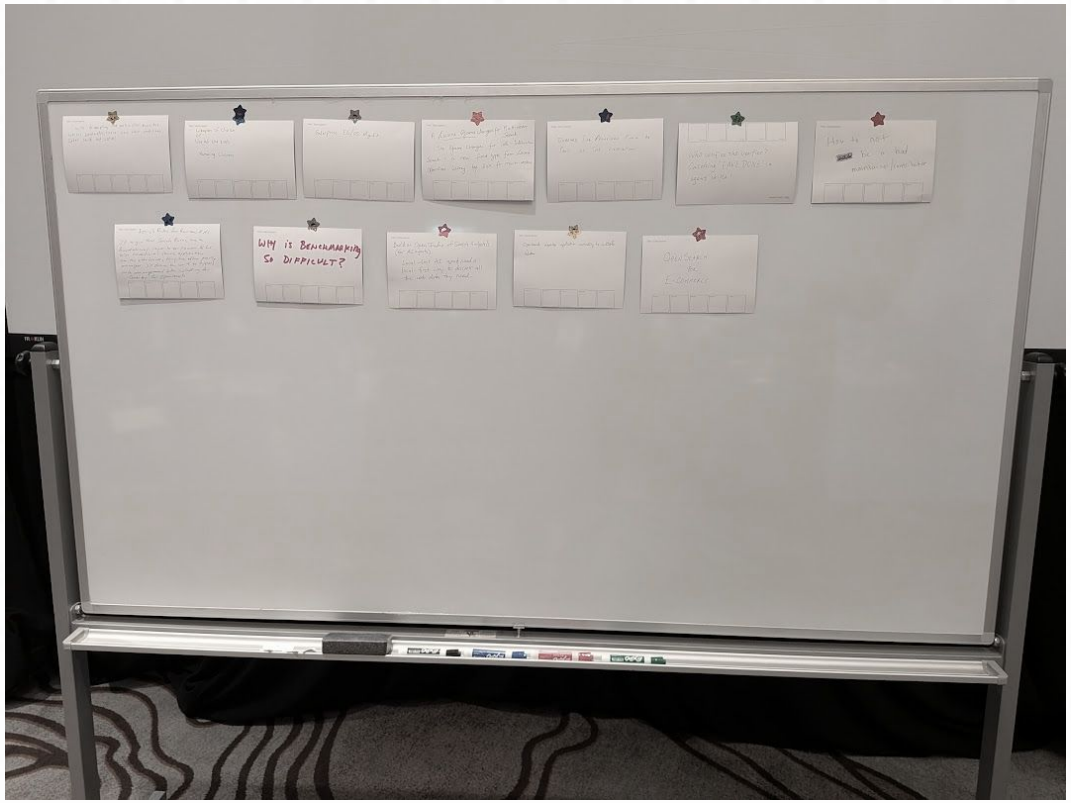
Everyone has something to share

They just need to be reminded of that

Submit your idea

Time to run your conference ‘panel’

Everyone places their proposal on the wall – this is about as anonymous as we can get



Vote with your smiles

Enable voting

With smiles, of course 😀



Chaos = engagement





Time to vote

After the 10 minute window is over, everyone is encouraged to come up and use the next 10 minutes to vote – *all at the same time*

Vote with your smiles

Enable voting

With smiles, of course 😀







Volunteers



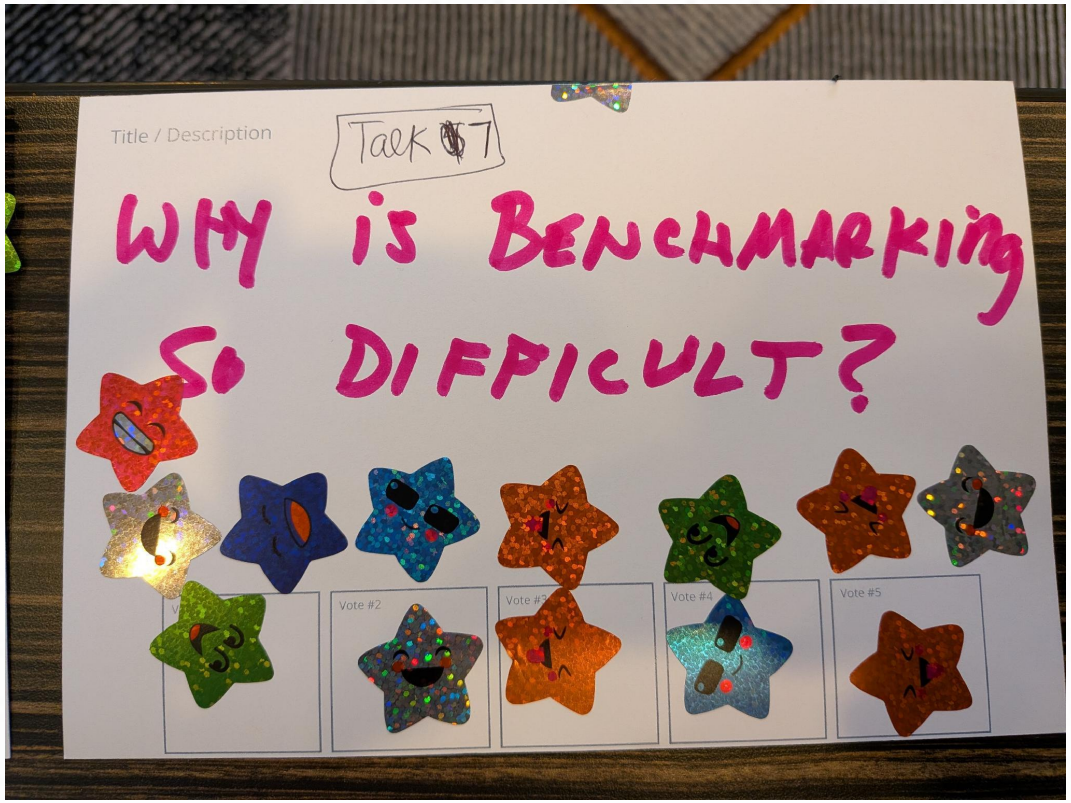
Bring in friends to help

Share the fun with those that contribute in many ways

Who’s up first

Count the votes

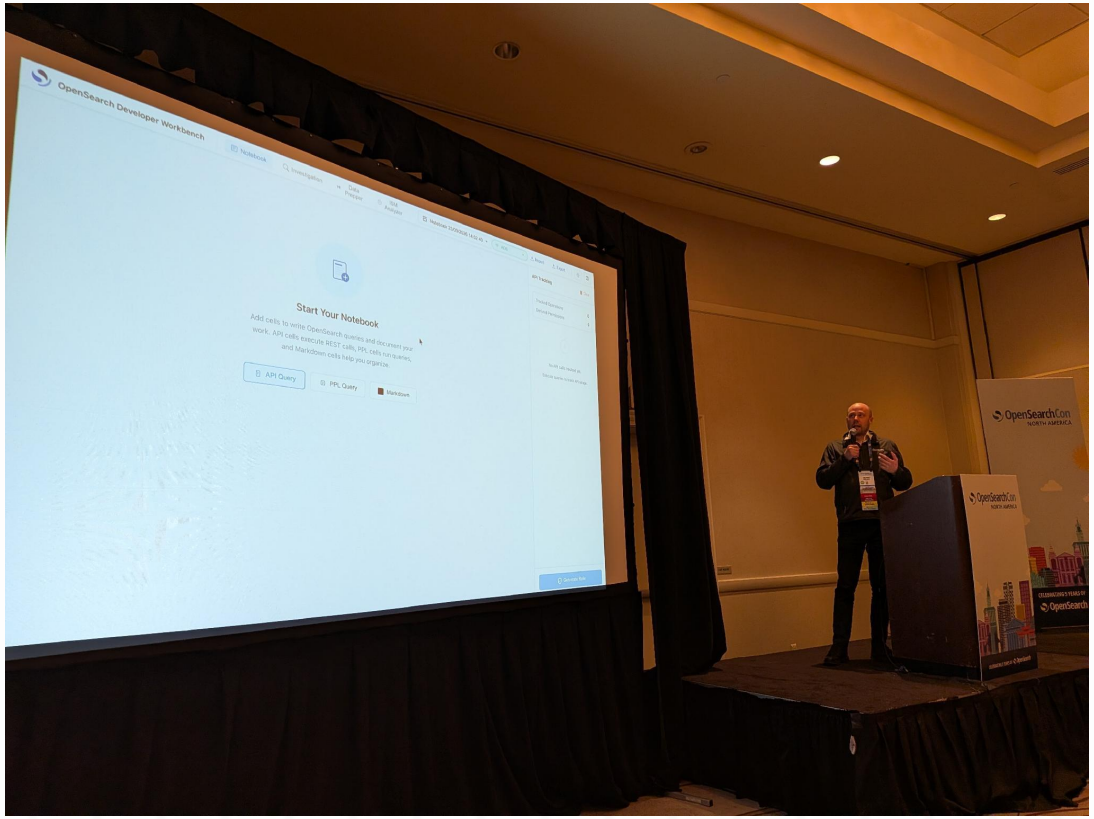
See what order everything goes in



Expectations

Subjects can vary greatly, and that’s a good thing

Spare time coding



Demos

An engineer wrote this utility in his free time and wanted to run it by the community for feedback

Full presentation

Over-achiever

CFPs to Unconference talks for our community



Another full presentation



A 15-minute version

40 minutes condensed to 15 can be super interesting

Improv

Passion on the stage

An engineer knows their audience, and it is an adventure to watch



Live feedback



“By a show of hands”

Another fantastic way for the speaker to engage with the audience.

Product launch

Surprise!

We’re doing a thing



Questions to the audience



He just had questions

Well, you have a room full of literal experts in the field!

Notes for organizers

Lessons learned after conducting these for a few years

Things to remember

A second chance	Use this during your accept/decline emails, at least in socials
Promote participation	*Almost* everyone has an idea to share; you may need to remind them though
Open forum	Do not assign any topics - this takes care of itself
Captive audience	Since you only announce right before they go on-stage, you have a captive audience
Courtesy	Remind people to stick around once they are done with their talk (gotcha sometimes)
CHAOS	Chaos really does bring engagement
Trust	Trust the community and have fun

Questions & Discussion

Let's orchestrate controlled chaos together.

Thank you

Thank you



Keep in touch

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